service thus became an elite within the elite of the country's permanent bureaucracy.

In addition to the personalities and institutions, external relations of any country are also defined by its sense of self and its view of its place in the world. The overarching idea that shaped Indian foreign policy right after Independence was the notion of India's geostrategic as well as civilizational primacy. India occupies the largest area of the South Asian subcontinent. Surrounded by the Himalayan mountain ranges to the north and the Indian Ocean to the south, Indians believe geography has dictated that the subcontinent is one entity.

For every Indian government security has meant ensuring that the subcontinent remains stable and peaceful. India's outlook on its immediate neighbours is heavily influenced by the Indian view that these countries are an integral part of Indian civilization. While the concept of a geographic 'sphere of influence' for a major power is widely understood, Indian philosophers and empires have, over time, also delineated a 'civilizational sphere of influence'[6] for India.



Located at the intersection of the trade routes between South Asia, Central Asia and the Middle East, ancient Indian kingdoms and empires maintained cultural and economic relations with Mesopotamia, Greece, China and Rome. With the exception of the Chola dynasty (300 BC–AD 1300), which built an overseas empire, Indian armies did not seek conquest of lands outside the subcontinent. Ancient Hindu treatises on statecraft and religion recommended isolation from other civilizations. Kings could conquer territory from neighbouring kings within India but annexing other cultures or peoples was deemed unethical.

Ancient Indian philosophers and strategists fall both in the realist as well as the idealist camps. The foremost strategist and writer on Indian realism